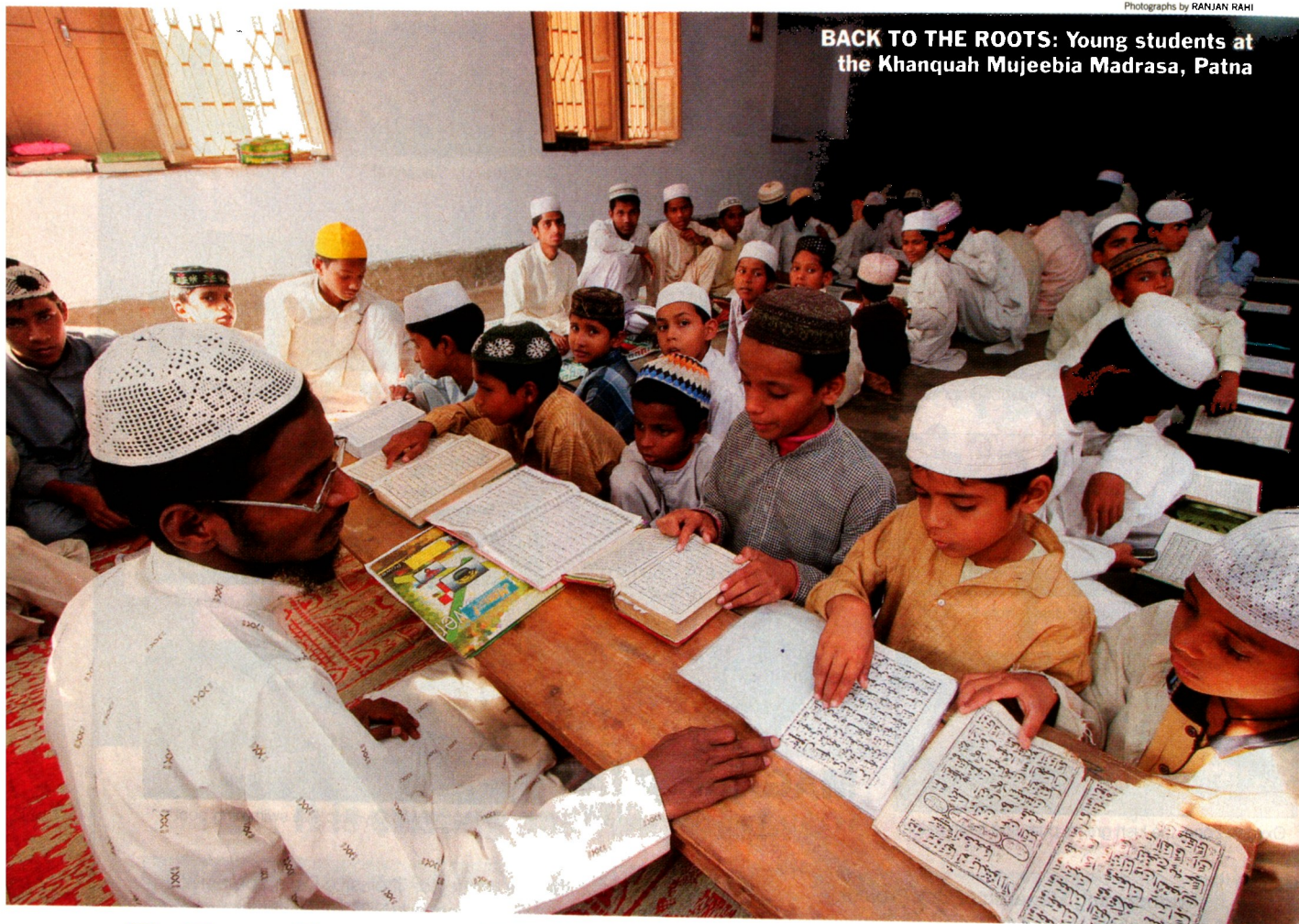


Photographs by RANJAN RAHI

BACK TO THE ROOTS: Young students at the Khanquah Mujeebia Madrasa, Patna



United by GOD

People across vast swathes of the country wear their spirituality on the sleeve as they rediscover traditional religious values

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

Students at the Khanquah Mujeebia Madrasa, Patna, sit cross-legged on the floor reciting the holy verse. For them, being able to recite the word of Allah by heart is an accomplishment. There is no television, no radio, no Internet, and no music system in the madrasa that houses a mosque and a hostel. The boys have been sent here for a better education as the state has done little to provide quality education to Muslims. They don't eat chocolates or fast food and there are no peals of laughter either. "The Quran

tells the Muslims their mission in life. We are here for enjoining the good, forbidding the wrong, and believing in God," says nine-year-old Danish, a wonder kid who can recite as many verses from the holy book as students twice his age do. The child is all modesty as he declares: "It is all due to the blessings of Allah. Besides, the credit rests with the teachers." Children here begin with namaz at 5 a.m. which is followed by breakfast. Classes commence at 7 a.m., lunch is at 12.10 p.m. followed by prayers and more classes till 4 p.m. Then students